

new silver bullet in the form of Kinect back in 2010, its little surprise that the new Xbox One is an important piece of Microsoft's future success. Through the Xbox One, the company stands to consolidate its foothold in the gaming market and make some serious inroads into TV and online entertainment and streaming services.

Amazon

These are great times for the world's largest online retailer, a company that began back in 1995 selling books on the Internet. If reading is your passion, then look no further than Amazon. The company sells arguably the biggest stockpile of digitized books in the world and also the best device to read it on. Apple and Google try to challenge Amazon's empire but with little success – Amazon's Kindle and reading apps bow to no one. For now.

In the world of ecommerce, as long as you go online to buy something, Amazon.com has such strong brand recall that people routinely bypass Google to search for a particular item, choosing to search it on Amazon instead and purchase it instantaneously. Far from being a retailer, a flurry of influx of third-party sellers on Amazon.com paves the way for the website's future as an online marketplace. Kind of like eBay, only much bigger! With Amazon widening its presence across the globe, we won't be surprised if it becomes the only destination for buying stuff online.

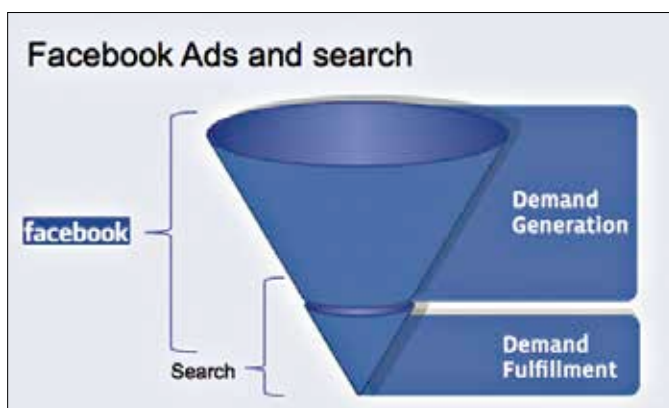
Yet that won't be Amazon's legacy, as it continues to attack new business opportunities. Apart from selling and delivering physical goods the world over, the company's making huge inroads to sell and deliver digital goods – self-publishing, digital downloads, and gaming, in particular. And all this while Amazon Web Services continues to grow by providing cheap, scalable cloud hosting with ease, giving webmasters a mind-boggling, unrivalled array of hosted services. It may sound prophetic, but all indications are that Amazon has its sights set on driving the Internet and hosting a substantial part of it on their servers. Its competitors, be warned!

Facebook

Everyone's favourite social network continues to be the most visited website on the world with over a billion registered users and several hundred million logging in everyday, spending a lot of time on the website. Facebook arguably has the best ways to profile and track its users right down to their minutest detail, better even than Google, yet its revenues are barely a fraction in comparison. So much for being the apple of everyone's online eye.

But something changed last year, when Facebook went public. Facebook can now be viewed in two major parts, pre-IPO and post-IPO. Before 2012, it was all about building an online destination that would be cool and engaging, which Facebook did quite brilliantly. After 2012, the company's focus and efforts seemed aimed towards building an innovative ad delivery network with a laser-like precision. According to an interview by Vanity Fair, Sheryl Sandberg, Facebook's COO, recalls that Facebook and its decision makers "became committed to ads" as early as 2008, when the social network mulled over its future business direction. What that means is Facebook's priority isn't so much about adding to the ethos of its social networking roots, but building a world-class ad delivery network.

Since then, features like Graph Search, Facebook Home, News Feed ads, have all come along well, but what has really reinvigorated the company's mixed fortunes and lethargic outlook is its targeted ads network for phones. Analysts believe Facebook has really cracked the code to make ads work for mobile and apps – better than Google even. It may well have, given that mobile ad revenue's contributing close to a quarter of the company's revenues. And the advertisers seem happy. Ka-ching!



What Facebook is trying to do, essentially, is to focus on ads

Intel

The world's leading PC chip manufacturer, Intel finds itself lagging behind in the only humongously profitable hardware market segment – tablets and smartphones – a fact resonated by the company's new CEO, Brian Krzanich, when he confirmed, "We were slow to respond to the ultramobile PC trend." Telling words indeed.

As far as Intel's concerned, its desktop PC and laptop biz isn't dead weight, it just isn't growing as per expectations. The growing significance of tablets can't be ignored, hence Intel's focus on all things "ultramobile" (re: tablets and small form factor PCs) devices. At Computex in June, what we gauged Intel means by "tablets" isn't just "slates" but "2-in-1" hybrid devices in a netbook-like form factor at least. By all indications, Intel's Atom processor is to play a pivotal role in shaping its ultramobile future, so much so that Intel's proclaimed to treat Atom with equal importance as its Core processor line. By ramping up its 14-nm fabrication process, later this year, Intel hopes to minimize power draw – without compromising performance – to a whole new level. Goosebumps, eh?

It's no secret that Intel trails ARM in the smartphone biz but advancement in its Silvermont and Bay Trail Atom chips promises to drive down costs and power consumption, giving ARM a real run for its money very soon.

Adobe

In May this year, Adobe gave a strong vote of confidence to software-as-a-service and cloud apps. It killed its beloved Creative Suite brand, of selling boxed software, and announced all future versions of its CS apps to be available on its Creative Cloud service. Fancy accessing Adobe's apps only through the Internet in the near future for a fixed monthly fee? Why are we not excited?

It seems Adobe's mind is made up and there's no turning back in the offing. To woo existing and new users to its Creative Cloud, it's trying two things. One is by offering more than just apps to work with by virtue of social tools (messaging, updates, chats, etc) that allows for better collaboration. The other is by dabbling into the hardware business by launching a stylus for smartphone users called Project Mighty and an innovative ruler-cum-layout tool called Project Napoleon. Will it be enough incentive for users to migrate com-